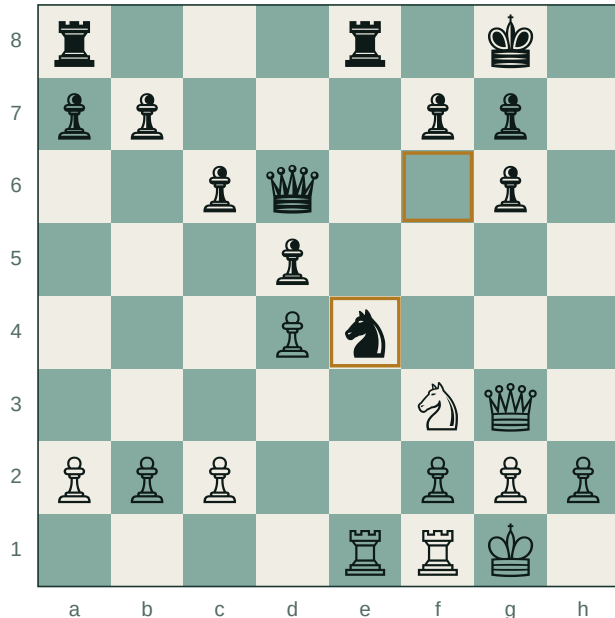


Capture the defender: White, move 17

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 16...Ne4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17. Rxe4 dxe4 18. Qxd6

17.Rxe4 The rook captures the knight on e4. Recorded reply: **17...dxe4**.

18.Qxd6 The queen captures the queen on d6.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +7. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +7: the balance goes from +0 to +7. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.